



BEFORE

After the [fall of Atlanta](#), Sherman weighed up his next move, even as Confederate General John Bell Hood intended to maneuver him into battle.

A STRATEGIC SHIFT

Having left Atlanta, John Bell Hood and his Army of Tennessee still hoped to bring Sherman to battle. But after pushing Hood into northern Alabama, Sherman left him there, assigning George Thomas's **Army of the Cumberland** to protect the Union rear. He turned his back on Hood, having persuaded a reluctant Lincoln and Grant to approve instead a **march through Georgia** to the sea.

SHERMAN'S PLAN

Sheridan, in devastating the Shenandoah Valley, had **demonstrated the effectiveness of a scorched-earth policy** (see [Utter devastation](#)). Sherman planned a similar campaign on a larger scale, torching everything that his army could not consume and **waging total war** on the South.

On November 15, 1864, General Sherman's 62,000 soldiers filed out of their camps around Atlanta, many marching over the battlefields of the previous summer. From their high vantage point, they could look back over the debris of empty cartridge boxes and shredded breastworks, and observe a terrible sight—Atlanta, in the distance, engulfed in a vast sheet of flame and smoke. Sherman, having declared it a Union fortress and deported its citizens, was burning the city in the process of abandoning it. Atlanta would never be useful to another Confederate army.

Before them more destruction awaited. Sherman's rule of never returning by the road he had come meant his veterans were leaving behind their old lifeline—the single-track railroad around which they had maneuvered their way to Atlanta. Having dispatched adequate forces to shadow General John Bell Hood's wounded Army of Tennessee in Alabama, Sherman was heading for the sea. He had persuaded Lincoln and Grant that a march to the Georgia coast was a good idea—putting his chosen 62,000 within easy reach of troop transports that could ferry them to Petersburg. The general had convinced himself that by cutting a path of destruction through the heart of the Confederacy, he might “make Georgia howl.”

Sherman's orders